

CHICKEN AND MASH

It was 4 p.m. on a summer afternoon when I arrived at the vineyard restaurant.

Perched on a hill. Rows of green vines. Sprawling garden. Sky bright blue, not a cloud in sight. The kind of day that makes you feel like New Zealand is the best place on earth.

The kitchen was immaculate.

Highly organised. Clean in a way that only professional kitchens are. And the smell—rich, deep, almost sweet. Beef stock simmering somewhere in the back.

I was met by the sous chef.

They called him Fat Sam.

Broad, solid, rounded stomach, rosy red cheeks that made him look jolly until you heard him speak. Voice low, abrupt. Firm. He moved quickly for a man his size, and in near silence.

Unnerving.

"You the trial?"

"Yeah."

"Get changed. Locker room's through there."

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I changed into my whites. Black Blundstones. Blue-and-white checked pants. White jacket. White apron. Polished my steel cap. Tied my apron.

Walked back into the kitchen.

Immediately got in the way.

I didn't know the layout. Didn't know the systems. Didn't know where anything was. The team was prepping for service, moving like a machine, and I was already a wrench in the gears.

"You hungry?"

Fat Sam asks as he pushes me out of his way using only his size.

"Uh—"

"I'll get you something."

At the time, I just thought he was being nice.

I realised years later and in hindsight, that he just wanted me out of his way and keep me occupied until Chef returned.

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He plated me a meal.

Simple.

Bone-in chicken supreme. Mashed potatoes. Asparagus. Chicken jus.

I stood at the steel prep bench in the back half of the kitchen, looking out the window into a staff-only courtyard. Sky still bright blue. I could hear the first tickets being called in the distance. The sound of protein hitting a hot pan. The low hum of the dishwasher.

I cut into the chicken.

Almost pearlescent white. Glossy in texture. I'd never seen chicken like this before.

The jus was crystal clear and thin. Barely clinging to the plate.

The asparagus were peeled and vibrant green. The mash was velvet smooth.

I took a little of each component on my fork.

Put it in my mouth, it stopped me dead mid-chew.

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Complete euphoria. Excitement. A small amount of fear.

I mentally checked out entirely.

Staring out the window for what felt like minutes.

I was hit with an internal monologue, a rolling sea of rhetorical questions:

Will I get this job?

How can chicken taste like this?

I'll never get this job.

What is this sauce?

I have to get this job.

Remember to breathe.

Contain the excitement.

Fat Sam popped his head around the corner.

"You like your dinner?"

Someone is talking to you.

It took me a moment to register where I was. What the fuck was happening.

Someone is talking to you.

You need to answer.

"I have to learn to cook like this," I said.

He laughed. Short, sharp.

"It's just chicken and mash, mate. You'll learn a lot more than that here."

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I couldn't believe what I was experiencing. But Sam was right.

It was just chicken and mash.

But how?

* * *

By the time I finished, Chef had arrived.

We stood outside while he smoked. Talked about food and kitchens and what I wanted to learn. I didn't work that service, but I stayed and watched.

Part deer in the headlights.

Part kid on Christmas morning.

At the end of the night, he offered me the job.

I said yes.

* * *

The drive home took an hour. I don't remember any of it.

Just the stupid grin I couldn't wipe off my face. The steering wheel under my hands. The feeling that for once—for the first fucking time—I knew exactly where I was going.

Not because of the job offer. Not because of the vineyard or the bright blue sky or even the chicken—though I still think about that chicken.

For the first time in my life, I had a direction. A path I'd chosen—not been forced into, not stumbled onto, not assigned by a parole officer with a dying pot plant and a golden retriever on her desk.

This was mine.

And I was going to chase it with everything I had.

I didn't know yet what that would cost. What I'd give up. What I'd miss. The birthdays and anniversaries and ordinary Tuesday nights that would slip past while I stood over a hot stove, chasing something I couldn't quite name.

I didn't know any of that.

I was young. Invincible. Certain that there would always be more time.